

COMPARISON · SPLIT · STRUCTURE

before-after

Explicit state-change comparison — what was, what is.

What writing decisions down actually changed.

BEFORE .

Decisions lived in the room they were made in. Six months on, nobody could say why we killed the project — only that someone senior had felt strongly. Every quarter relitigated the same three debates from memory.



AFTER .

Every decision is logged with its signals, its options, and the bet it made. We still relitigate, but now there is a record showing we already decided this in March. We ignore it, but faster.

What the operating review changed.

BEFORE

Status arrived as a 40-slide deck nobody finished; the real decision happened in the hallway afterward.



AFTER

One scorecard, one page; the call is logged in the room before anyone leaves.

What writing decisions down actually changed.

BEFORE .

Decisions lived in the room they were made in. Six months on, nobody could say why we killed the project — only that someone senior had felt strongly. Every quarter relitigated the same three debates from memory.



AFTER .

Every decision is logged with its signals, its options, and the bet it made. We still relitigate, but now there is a record showing we already decided this in March. We ignore it, but faster.

What writing decisions down actually changed.

BEFORE.

Decisions lived in the room they were made in. Six months on, nobody could say why we killed the project — only that someone senior had felt strongly. Every quarter relitigated the same three debates from memory.



AFTER.

Every decision is logged with its signals, its options, and the bet it made. We still relitigate, but now there is a record showing we already decided this in March. We ignore it, but faster.

What writing decisions down actually changed.

BEFORE .

Decisions lived in the room they were made in. Six months on, nobody could say why we killed the project — only that someone senior had felt strongly. Every quarter relitigated the same three debates from memory.



AFTER .

Every decision is logged with its signals, its options, and the bet it made. We still relitigate, but now there is a record showing we already decided this in March. We ignore it, but faster.

When NOT to reach for before-after.

Two competing options. Use `compare-prose` or `split-compare` when both sides are alternatives under consideration. before-after is for a change that already happened.

More than two states. If there is a middle state or a sequence of changes, use `list-steps` to show the progression. before-after is binary by construction.

Editorial labels on the cards. The card label is always Before or After. Renaming them to Old way / New way defeats the universal grammar and breaks reader expectations.

See also.

RELATED COMPONENTS

`compare-prose` — two alternatives being weighed, not a transformation

`split-compare` — binary decision with a verdict bar

`redline` — the change is in verbatim text, not structural state

`list-steps` — the change has more than two phases